average and, at most, twice a week. I know many users who charge their EVs once every two weeks, and others who do so even less frequently for their daily use. Simply put, for a high-end EV like Hyundai's Ioniq 5, with an annual running of 15,000 km, one would theoretically need to charge the car just 30 times—about twice or thrice a month, depending on usage.

Long-distance journeys: There is a notion that EVs are fine for city driving with the availability of chargers as well as charging options at home or office, but one can also undertake long, or even really long, road trips with just a little bit of planning. Third-party apps, EV manufacturers' aggregation apps and service providers' apps provide easy access to the 20,000-plus public fast chargers that have already come up across the country, and the number is growing very fast. I have driven across India in EVs, in one instance, on the Golden Quadrilateral with the Mercedes EQS and, in another, to the north of Kashmir in a Hyundai Ioniq 5.



OEM-driven ultra-fast charging networks are a boon at most major touch points across the country. This one by Mercedes-Benz in Kolkata can give the EQS 600km of range in 50 minutes

Safety: On the one hand, EVs are among the most technologically advanced cars available, often equipped with the latest passive and active safety features. In this day and age, they are just as prone to catching fire as ICE (internal combustion engine) vehicles. On the other hand, when EVs do catch fire, they burn with greater intensity, making the fires harder to douse. Modern car batteries are better when it comes to water wading and are more stable than their ICE counterparts because they are relatively heavier. They also have a much higher chance of surviving monsoon water-logging and will not die on you in such cases as the high voltage electrical systems are all sealed and made waterproof. There is no mechanical place where water can enter and cripple the car! Also, given that the consumption of power and thereby electric charge increases rapidly with increasing speeds, EVs encourage moderation of speed or else offer you the prospect of drastically reduced range.

City driving: EVs are best for city driving and are most efficient at low speeds and in stop-and-go traffic, unlike ICE cars, which are most efficient in the top overdrive gear at moderate speeds, ranging from 60kmph to 100kmph in most cases, and within a very narrow speed band. Electric motors that power EVs retain their peak torque through most of their rev range and produce it from the word go. Besides, all EVs are equipped with various levels of recuperation that put the kinetic energy back into the batteries each time speed needs to be scrubbed off either through braking or by lifting off.

An EV as a second car: Most people think that EVs are best suited as the second or third car at home. However, this is a counter-productive notion as the biggest economic and environmental advantage over ICE cars comes from lower running costs and the absence of pollution. Therefore, an EV should be the family's primary car, logging the most kilometres, while an ICE alternative should be used for fill-in trips or in use-case scenarios where an EV is not practical. ■

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